

Venomous snakes

There are around 3,850 species of snakes around the world, and about 20 percent of these are venomous. They use their venom to kill their prey—but some also strike in self-defense and, when they do so, some species can be dangerous to humans, such as the ones shown here.

Arabian Peninsula

Saw-scaled viper

With a dangerous bite, and often found living close to humans, this snake is probably responsible for more human deaths than any other. Similar saw-scaled vipers occur elsewhere on the Arabian Peninsula and in parts of Africa.

INDIA

Indian cobra

The Indian cobra is an elapid that warns anyone approaching that it will strike in self-defense. It extends ribs close to its neck to produce a flat hood, while rising up to appear bigger.

ASIA

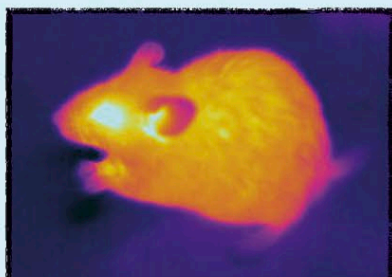
Many-banded krait

Kraits are boldly patterned elapid snakes found across Asia. Living near water, the many-banded krait hides during the day and hunts at night, preying on fish. If surprised, it uses its deadly bite in self-defense.

AUSTRALIA

Tiger snake

The tiger snake is one of many highly venomous elapid snakes found in Australia. Individuals vary in color and not all have the stripes that give the species its name.



Hunting by heat

Vipers have an extra sense that helps them locate prey. Heat-sensitive pits on their head allow them to “see” the body heat of warm-blooded animals, in the same way that the mouse shows up against a cold background in this thermal image.

ABOUT 200
SNAKE SPECIES
HAVE **VENOM**
THAT IS HARMFUL
TO **HUMANS**

AROUND
138,000
PEOPLE DIE
FROM A SNAKE
BITE EVERY YEAR

